CHAPTER 6 :

ON THE BLEEDING EDGE

If there is one thing to take away from *Iron Man*, it's that Tony Stark's miraculous suit of armor will always represent the white-hot edge where the tried-and-true technology of the past meets the seemingly impossible ideas of tomorrow. And necessity is the mother of reinvention. It is obvious in the development of the Mark I, Mark II and Mark III suits that Tony is relentless in his pursuit of technological superiority, and that he is often driven by a need to adapt to the challenges he faces. After interacting with an F-35 that can fly at Mach 4, Tony will design his suit so it can fly faster. After experiencing an icing problem at 5,000 feet, Tony will design his suit so it can fly farther. And when his armor takes the full brunt of a tank's artillery shell, he will use that information to build it safer. The determination to accept nothing less than perfection in his armor manifests in other areas of his life: in his weapons systems; in his planes; in his cars, toys and gadgets; and in the very heart of a hero. The challenge for *Iron Man*'s designers was to not only play futurist and imagine the improbable, but to also make it look possible, grounded and as realistic as a new-model car on a showroom floor. Their task was to make sure that anything that came off a Stark assembly line, whether it was the Jericho missile or a souped-up Humvee, represented in form and function the bleeding edge of technological ingenuity.

After all, that's how Dad did it, that's how America does it, and it's worked out pretty well for Tony Stark so far.

